



Why April's 3.8% Inflation Reads Truer Than November's 2.7%

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 The April 2026 Consumer Price Index put headline inflation at 3.8% year-over-year, the highest reading since May 2023, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics. Five months earlier the same index had read 2.7%, below what economists expected. Read straight across, that looks like a sudden jump of more than a full percentage point in less than half a year. The straightforward reading is that prices reaccelerated hard in the spring, and there is real heat in the April numbers: energy rose 3.8% on the month and accounted for over 40% of the monthly increase, with gasoline up 28.4% from a year prior on Middle East supply disruption. So the surface story holds up to a point.

2 The trouble is that one of the two endpoints was never a clean measurement. The federal government shut down from October 1 through November 12, 2025, the BLS suspended most CPI operations, and for the first time since January 1921 no monthly CPI report was published at all. [Cumulative and periodic sentences] The agency could not collect October price data and said it could not go back and collect it later. For that missing reference period it carried September survey figures forward, which meant the index effectively assumed no price change for shelter, including rent and owners' equivalent rent. Shelter is not a minor line. It carries more than 40% of the weight in the core index.

3 Diane Swonk, chief economist, called the implied zero housing inflation in the November report 'a wacky number' and warned it would 'anchor the index going forward.' [Logos] Other economists told readers to take the figure with 'the entire salt shaker.' The November 2.7% was not a measurement that came in low. It was a measurement that was partly switched off, then averaged in as though the lights had stayed on. September, the last fully collected month before the gap, had run at 3.0%.

4 What happened in April was the correction, not a new shock. The BLS housing survey rotates its panel on a six-month cycle; when the panel that should have been read in October finally came back around in April, it converged, compressing two cycles into one reporting period. [Diction] Shelter rose 0.6% on the month, with rent and owners' equivalent rent each up 0.5%. Core inflation moved to 2.8% from 2.6%. The March reading had already been 3.3%, driven mostly by energy. [Logos] So part of the April number is genuine current pressure from fuel, and part is the shelter data catching up to where it had quietly been all along.

5 None of this makes April's prices lower in real terms than the headline says. The point is narrower: the 2.7% understated, the 3.8% does not, and the gap between them is mostly the width of a hole the shutdown punched in the record rather than the distance prices actually traveled. [Antithesis] For a reader trying to gauge where inflation sits, the more reliable of the two figures is the later one, built on data the earlier one was missing. The November print remains in the official series, flagged by the people who compile it, an artifact left in place because the rules do not allow it to be filled back in.

Devices, and why they are here:

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 2): “The federal government shut down from October 1 through November 12, 2025, the BLS suspended most CPI operations, and for the first time since January 1921 no monthly CPI report was published at all.”

The long cumulative sentence stacks the shutdown, the suspended operations, and the broken 1921 streak in one breath, letting the scale of the data gap accumulate as fact rather than be asserted as alarming. It carries the concession's pivot into the rebuttal without raising the voice.

Logos (paragraph 3): “Diane Swonk, chief economist, called the implied zero housing inflation in the November report 'a wacky number' and warned it would 'anchor the index going forward.’”

An attributed expert judgment ('a wacky number', 'anchor the index') supplies the evidentiary turn: the author lets a named economist's reasoning, not the author's own conviction, certify that the November figure is unreliable. Credibility is borrowed from the cited record.

Diction (paragraph 4): “The BLS housing survey rotates its panel on a six-month cycle; when the panel that should have been read in October finally came back around in April, it converged, compressing two cycles into one reporting period.”

The technical vocabulary of the survey mechanism (rotating panel, six-month cycle, converged, compressing two cycles) does the explaining flatly and precisely, signaling the writer understands the method and framing the spike as procedure rather than drama.

Logos (paragraph 4): “The March reading had already been 3.3%, driven mostly by energy.”

Setting the 3.3% March figure beside the April rise isolates how much of April is ongoing energy pressure and how much is shelter catch-up, building the conclusion by evidence rather than claim. Placed here it keeps the reasoning honest about the part of April that is genuinely new.

Antithesis (paragraph 5): “The point is narrower: the 2.7% understated, the 3.8% does not, and the gap between them is mostly the width of a hole the shutdown punched in the record rather than the distance prices actually traveled.”

The balanced contrast of '2.7% understated, the 3.8% does not' sets the two readings against each other to land the verdict the whole piece has built toward, doing it in parallel form so the judgment reads as the residue of the facts.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the final paragraph, the writer concedes that the April figure does not make prices 'lower in real terms' primarily in order to

- A) establish that energy, not shelter, was the decisive driver of the April increase
- B) shift the argument toward predicting where inflation will move in the months following April
- C) concede that the earlier 2.7% reading was an accurate description of consumer costs after all
- D) preserve the reliability of the later reading while narrowing the claim to one about measurement rather than price levels

2. The writer's phrasing that the November figure 'was a measurement that was partly switched off, then averaged in as though the lights had stayed on' primarily serves to

- A) celebrate the resilience of the statistical system under the strain of a shutdown
- B) accuse the Bureau of Labor Statistics of deliberately concealing the true inflation rate
- C) concede that the carry-forward method was the most accurate option available
- D) render a methodological gap as a concrete failure of recording without resorting to emotive judgment words

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer D. The keyed reading is correct because the writer grants a limit (April's number is not about real prices being lower) precisely to keep the claim narrow and defensible: November understated, April does not. The option saying the 2.7% was accurate after all inverts the relationship, since the whole passage treats that figure as switched off and unreliable. The option about predicting future months imports a forward-looking purpose the level, status-report close never adopts. The option naming energy as the decisive driver is true but not the function asked, since the concession's job is to bound the claim about measurement, not to rank causes.

2. Answer D. The keyed answer fits because the lights-and-switch image makes an abstract carry-forward procedure tangible while the surrounding tone stays flat and unemotive, which is how this register carries feeling through fact rather than adjectives. The accusation-of-concealment option overstates into an extreme the text does not support, since the writer treats the gap as a rule-bound necessity, not a cover-up. The celebration option inverts the tone, which is critical of the figure, not admiring. The option calling carry-forward the most accurate method available is contradicted by the passage, which presents it as the source of the distortion.

Discussion questions:

- 1. The piece argues that a later measurement can be more trustworthy than an earlier one even when the later number is higher and more alarming. How does the writer use attribution and method (naming the BLS, the shutdown dates, the carry-forward procedure, an economist's quote) to make that counterintuitive claim feel forced by the evidence rather than asserted?
- 2. The writer concedes real points to the 'surface story' (genuine energy pressure, gasoline up 28.4%) before turning. Identify where the concession ends and the rebuttal begins, and discuss whether the concession is substantial enough that a reader briefly wonders which reading the writer trusts.

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The writer earns the counterintuitive verdict by refusing to claim it personally. Every load-bearing move is attributed: the BLS suspended operations, the agency said it could not recollect October data, Diane Swonk called the housing figure 'a wacky number.' By the time the antithesis arrives in the last paragraph ('the 2.7% understated, the 3.8% does not'), the judgment reads as the residue the facts leave behind rather than the writer's opinion. The method paragraph does the same work: explaining the six-month rotating panel converging in April lets the reader see why the spike is a correction, so the conclusion feels demonstrated, not announced.

2. The concession runs through the first paragraph and into the energy facts: the writer grants that April shows 'real heat,' with energy at 3.8% on the month and gasoline up 28.4%, and explicitly says 'the surface story holds up to a point.' The rebuttal opens on 'The trouble is that one of the two endpoints was never a clean measurement.' The concession is substantial because the energy figures are real current pressure the writer never takes back, even in the close ('part of the April number is genuine current pressure from fuel'). A reader can briefly believe the straightforward reacceleration story, which is what makes the methodological turn land rather than feel like a setup.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener argues that a later, higher inflation reading was more trustworthy than an earlier, lower one because the earlier figure rested on incomplete data. This raises a broader question about official statistics. Write an essay in which you defend, challenge, or qualify the following claim: when an official measurement is known to be distorted, the public is better served by leaving the flawed figure in the record, clearly flagged, than by removing or revising it. Support your argument with reasoning and examples from your reading, observation, or experience.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Reading the 3.8% as proof that inflation suddenly accelerated by more than a point in five months. The piece's point is that most of the gap is a measurement artifact from the October data hole, not actual price movement; the antithesis in the final paragraph ('the 2.7% understated, the 3.8% does not') marks exactly this distinction.
- Treating the November 2.7% as simply wrong or fabricated. The writer presents it as partly uncollected then carried forward under the rules, a necessity rather than an error or a deception, and notes it remains in the official series flagged by its compilers.
- Mistaking the economist quotes for the writer's own emotional outburst. The 'wacky number' and 'salt shaker' lines are attributed judgments the writer uses as logos (cited evidence), not the writer venting; the register keeps the author's own voice flat and lets the sourcing carry the weight.
- Assuming all of April's increase is the shelter catch-up. The writer is careful that part of April is genuine current energy pressure (the second logos move, setting March's 3.3% beside April) and part is shelter data converging, so the number is not a single cause.

AP exam alignment:

This opener teaches students to analyze how an argument can be built almost entirely from attributed evidence and visible method rather than from asserted conviction, and to track a concession-then-rebuttal structure across a passage. It models the Claims and Evidence and Style skills by showing how a writer braids logos with a flat, restrained tone, and how an antithesis at the close can deliver a verdict as the residue of fact. The Q3 prompt extends the passage's theme into a debatable proposition about the integrity of official statistics.